

Diane M. Mahon
Precinct 14

VOTE TO SUPPORT LOCAL BUSINESS AND ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT!

Please vote YES on Article 53, the Cullinane Substitute Motion.

YES: Cullinane Substitute Motion

NO: Mucaluso Substitute Motion

YES: Benson Amendment

As I was engaging with Arlington voters on the Override who were yes, no or undecided voters, I heard one unifying and consistent request from all three groups of voters....Arlington NEEDS more usable business development and more revenues from that development even if it comes in small, incremental steps.

Arlington faces a shortage of viable commercial space, making it difficult for new businesses to move to town and difficult for existing businesses to stay. Businesses are seeking spaces in the range of 2,000 - 5,000 square feet, and sometimes as much as 8,000 sf or more. The Chamber of Commerce and the town's Economic Development Coordinator have both emphasized the need for larger commercial spaces. The Redevelopment Board when it originally held the hearing on this Warrant Article had members Rachel Zsembery and Eugene Benson voting in favor of Article 53.

Article 53 preserves the original intent of the MBTA Communities Act commercial bonus. In exchange for additional height and easing of setbacks, the bylaw requires 60% ground-floor commercial space. The 60% requirement ensures that new spaces are large enough to be viable. Small storefronts often remain vacant. Why would we create more unusable commercial space? We have been hearing from businesses that want to operate their business here in Arlington, but they need more usable space.

The 60% requirement opens the door and welcomes a wider and more diverse range of businesses to Arlington. This approach is supported by public input, as well as the town's consultant (Utile), the town's Economic Development Coordinator, and the Chamber of Commerce.

The Cullinane motion restores a clear, proportional standard that applies across all MBTA overlay parcels on Mass Ave and Broadway, not just a single project. And answers the demand from residents that the town create a welcoming environment for new, growing businesses, while encouraging existing businesses to stay.